A Shift to Alliances with Ideologically Different Parties: The Change of 1967

The year 1967 was a turning point, with the Jan Sangh's decision to enter into electoral alliances with parties that did not share its ideology. After Mookerjee's death, the party had chosen to follow a 'closed' strategy. Its own social base remained narrow: primarily in urban areas, and among upper castes and traders. The Jan Sangh's cultural messaging had limited political impact at a time when, at the provincial level, the Congress was itself highly Hindu traditionalist. The ruling party's provincial leaders may have lost the larger secular–communal debate to Nehru in 1950-51, but at the district level, and below the elite levels of discourse, the ideological boundaries between Hindu nationalists (from the Jan Sangh and the RSS) and Congressmen remained 'fuzzy' through the 1950s. Below elite levels of discourse, there was little distinction between Congress attitudes on issues of Hindu nationalism and those of the Jan Sangh.[104]

When the Jan Sangh did make alliances, it did so with local power groups that had a narrow upper-caste base. In 1951, for example, it made small alliances with the Uttar Pradesh Praja Party, the Zamindar Party in Punjab and the Purusharthi Parishad in Ajmer.[105] Until the 1960s, it only entered into local seat adjustments, such as with the Swatantra Party.

By the late 1960s, the Jan Sangh had changed its policy. The key progenitors of this change were Nanaji Deshmukh and Atal Bihari Vajpayee—who advocated pre-poll alliances with diverse players, including the communists. This shift led to the Jan Sangh joining the Samyukta Vidhayak Dal (SVD), a grand alliance of Opposition parties against the Congress, in the national and state elections of 1967. Their combined might took the Congress to its lowest point ever in Parliament until then, and the party lost power in several states. New SVD governments came to power in several states with the Jan Sangh as a key partner. In UP, for example, the Jan Sangh won ninety-eight of 425 state assembly seats (the highest after the Congress's 199), as part of the SVD alliance. Jan Sangh leaders joined the new UP government in an alliance that included